WEEK 9

Advocacy and Activism

- Approaches to effective community engagement

Discourse on Development

- **Development and Social Cohesion**
- **Welfare State**

Advocacy and Activism

These terms are often used interchangeably but have slightly different meanings. In general, an activist is someone who takes intentional action to bring about social or political change. An advocate is someone who speaks on behalf of others to encourage change and reform.

Advocacy means using your voice, skills and networks to elevate the voices of others and encourage positive change from within systems and institutions. This can include encouraging open discussions about important issues with community members, contacting local politicians or community leaders to push for policy change, volunteering for social justice organizations, or participating in social media movements to raise awareness of a particular issue.

Activism involves taking deliberate action on behalf of a cause to challenge societal norms and systems in order to effect social change. This includes actions like organizing or attending protests, meeting with important leaders to push for policy or legal change on a particular topic or circulating petitions for signature. The term 'grassroots activism' is also often used to describe activism that occurs within local communities to create change at the local, regional and/or international level. Intersectional activism can be an extremely powerful means for providing minority groups with a voice, highlighting important civic issues and ultimately instigating political change.

Role of Advocacy in Addressing Social Issues:

Advocacy can involve individuals, groups, or organizations working to influence the government, businesses, or the general public to make improvements that benefit society. In Pakistan, advocacy has played a major role in solving various social issues.

1. **Raising Awareness**: Advocacy helps spread knowledge and understanding about a social issue. This is important because many people may not be aware of certain problems that exist in society. By raising awareness, advocacy can make more people care about the issue and support efforts to solve it.

2. **Influencing Policies and Laws**: Advocacy plays a key role in changing or improving government policies and laws. Advocates can organize campaigns, hold meetings with government officials, and create petitions to push for better laws that address social issues.

3.**Empowering Communities**: Advocacy helps give a voice to marginalized or vulnerable groups who may not have the power to speak for themselves. It empowers them by providing the tools, resources, and knowledge they need to advocate for their own rights and needs.

4. **Mobilizing Public Support**: Advocacy helps to organize people around a common cause. When many people support an issue, it puts pressure on leaders and decision-makers to take

action. This is called mobilizing public support and it often involves protests, media campaigns, or online petitions.

5. **Holding Governments and Institutions Accountable**: Advocacy often. involves holding governments, institutions, and organizations accountable for their promises and responsibilities, this can be done by monitoring their actions, demanding transparency, and calling for improvements where they fall short.

6**. Providing Support and Resources:** Advocacy organizations often provide direct help to people who are affected by social issues. This can include giving people legal - assistance, providing education or healthcare, or helping them access government services.

Advocacy and Activism as an important elements of Community Engagement

Advocacy and activism play a crucial role in **community engagement**, empowering individuals and groups to bring about social change, influence policies, and address pressing societal issues. Both concepts are deeply intertwined, as they enable communities to voice their concerns, challenge injustices, and drive meaningful transformations.

Advocacy involves speaking up for a cause, promoting awareness, and influencing decision-makers to create positive change. It can take various forms, such as lobbying for policy reforms, organizing awareness campaigns, or representing marginalized communities in decision-making processes. Effective advocacy helps bridge the gap between communities and policymakers, ensuring that local needs and concerns are addressed in governance and development initiatives.

Activism, on the other hand, is a more direct and action-oriented approach to community engagement. It often includes protests, demonstrations, grassroots movements, and digital campaigns aimed at challenging unjust systems and demanding change. Activism mobilizes people to participate in civic movements, holding institutions accountable and creating pressure for reform.

Together, **advocacy and activism** strengthen community engagement by fostering civic responsibility, encouraging collective action, and promoting inclusivity. Whether through legal reforms, social justice initiatives, or environmental movements, these components ensure that communities remain active participants in shaping their future rather than passive recipients of change.

Discourse on Development

Definition of Development The term “development” has various meanings to different people and can be explained in different contexts. For example, the development needs of a starving population must be different from those where there is sufficient nutrition (Matowanyka, 1991). Development has often been confused with “economic growth as measured solely in terms of annual increases in pre-capita income or gross national product, regardless of its distribution and the degree of people’s participation in effective growth” (Mahmoud, 1991). Seers (1972) asserted that “development means the conditions for realization of the human personality. Its evaluation must therefore take into account three linked criteria: where there has been a reduction in (1) poverty, (2) unemployment, (3) inequality”.

Development is defined by Todaro and Smith as a multi-dimensional process that involves major changes in social structures, popular attitudes, and national institutions, as well as economic growth, reduction of inequality, and eradication of absolute poverty.

According to Pearson (1992), development involves “An improvement qualitative, quantitative or both - in the use of available resources”. He also asserts that development does not refer to one particular perspective on social, political and economic betterment. Instead, it is a hybrid term for a myriad of strategies adopted for socioeconomic and environment transformation from current states to desired ones.

Dimensions of Development

Dimensions of Development is always multi-dimensional. Four important dimensions of development can be introduced here. They are: economic dimension, human dimension, sustainable dimension and the territorial dimension.

Economic development: Economic development is traditionally seen as the initial form of development. It has been strictly associated with the concept of economic growth determined through an increase in the per capita income. It proposes economic transformations to initiate growth and does not speak much about social transformation. However, soon it was realized that economic development cannot ensure true development as the benefits are cornered by a few.

Human development: people-centered development, where the focus is put on the improvement of the various dimensions affecting the well-being of individuals and their relationships with the society (health, education, entitlements, capabilities, empowerment etc.)

Sustainable development: development which considers the long-term perspectives of the socio-economic system, to ensure that improvements occurring in the short term will not be detrimental to the future status or development potential of the system, i.e. development will be "sustainable" on environmental, social, financial and other grounds.

Territorial development: development of a specific region (space) achievable by exploiting the specific socio-economic, environmental and institutional potential of the area, and its relationships with external subjects.

Development discourse refers to the way ideas, policies, and practices related to development are discussed, framed, and understood in academic, political, and practical contexts. It includes the language, narratives, and ideologies used to define development, such as economic growth, modernization, sustainability, and social progress. Development discourse shapes how problems are identified, solutions are proposed, and power dynamics are maintained or challenged in global and local development efforts.

Development discourse refers to the process of articulating knowledge and power through which particular concepts, theories, and practices for social change are created and reproduced.

The discourse on development has evolved significantly over time, with some scholars tracing its origins to the European Enlightenment, which emphasized reason, progress, and the scientific study of societies. However, the modern concept of development gained prominence after World War II

Around the end of World War II (WWII), a new mainstream development discourse emerged, primarily aimed at helping newly independent post-colonial nations and poorer countries catch up with their former colonizers. Initially, economic development was equated with economic growth and an increase in income per capita, as seen in the early United Nations (UN) reports (1947), which emphasized raising the welfare of entire populations. At this stage, social issues like poverty and life expectancy were considered secondary to economic expansion.

Following WWII, economists and policymakers increasingly focused on structured development models and planning, adapting their approaches over time. In the 1950s, development was primarily measured by income growth, but by the 1970s, concerns over unemployment and income distribution became part of the discourse. However, by the 1980s, high levels of external debt and economic downturns in creditor countries delayed development plans. The 1990s then saw a major shift with the disintegration of the Soviet Union, prompting many nations to transition from socialist to market economies.

Over time, the concept of development expanded beyond just economic growth to include education, health, and social well-being. As Thorbecke (2006) describes, this evolution transformed development from a single-dimensional concept focused on economic growth to a multi-dimensional approach incorporating multiple social and economic objectives. This shift reflected a broader understanding that sustainable development must address poverty, inequality, and quality of life, rather than just GDP growth.

The emergence of development theory

Mercantilism

Mercantilism was an economic system of trade that spanned the 16th century to the 18th century. Mercantilism was based on the principle that the world's wealth was static, and consequently, governments had to regulate trade to build their wealth and national power. Many European nations attempted to accumulate the largest possible share of that wealth by maximizing their exports and limiting their imports via tariffs.

Modernization Theory

Modernization theory sees development as a linear process through which societies progress from traditional to modern economies, following the path of Western nations. Walt Rostow's Stages of Economic Growth (1960) outlined five stages: traditional society, preconditions for take-off, take-off, drive to maturity, and age of mass consumption. The theory emphasizes industrialization, political development, cultural change, and adoption of Western institutions. However, it has been criticized for being Eurocentric and ignoring the unique conditions of developing nations.

Dependency Theory

Dependency Theory and World Systems Theory writers like Wallerstein criticize the increasing North-South gap, which comes from the 'core countries' in the North exploiting cheap natural resources and cheap labor in the 'peripheral countries' in the South.
This theory emerged as a critique of modernization theory, arguing that underdevelopment is not a stage but a result of historical exploitation by developed nations. Scholars from ECLA (Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean) argued that former colonies were structured to serve the economic interests of industrialized nations. This theory suggests that the global economic system perpetuates dependency by keeping developing countries in subordinate positions through unequal trade relations. It calls for reduced reliance on Western economies and strategies like Import Substitution Industrialization (ISI) to promote self-sufficiency.

World system theory

Developed by Immanuel Wallerstein, world systems theory classifies the global economy into core, periphery, and semi-periphery nations. The core nations (wealthy industrialized countries) dominate trade and technology, while periphery nations (developing countries) supply raw materials and labor, often under exploitative conditions. Semi-periphery nations act as intermediaries. This theory argues that capitalism maintains economic disparities and that true development requires breaking away from exploitative global structures.

Neoliberalism

Neoliberalism which has been pushed by the World Bank and the IMF for the last 40 years, says that lack of economic development arises from excessive government intervention in the economy. So, they recommend deregulation, privatization and unrestricted foreign investment, free trade and unlimited currency exchange. Neo liberalism was proven to be disastrous not only for poorer countries but also for the developed countries by marginalizing citizens to mere consumers of even the fundamental services such as basic food, education, health, clean water and even clean air. Most of the benefits went to elites and multinational corporations. In addition, increased imports and privatizations often resulted in more unemployment and sufferings for common citizens across the globe. Overall, most poor countries, e.g. in Africa, Asia and Latin America, experienced slower growth and continued poverty under neoliberalism.

Globalization Theory

Globalization theory focuses on global economic integration, communication, and cultural exchange. It views development as being shaped by technological advancements, trade liberalization, and multinational corporations. While globalization has increased economic opportunities, it has also led to inequalities and challenges for local economies. Critics argue that globalization reinforces Western dominance, making it difficult for developing nations to compete on equal terms.

Comparison between four main Theories of Development

Dimension	Modernisation	Dependency	World Systems	Globalisation
Definition & background	Development as a systematic process.	Elements of neo-Marxist theory.	Capitalism as the dominant system.	Greater global integration of economic transactions.
Model	US & Europe-centric. A normative model.	Revolution of under-developed nations	World- centric.	US & Europe- centric, a positive model.
Focus	Political; Cultural changes; Imposition of western values and policies.	Totality of society. Social system periphery.	Relations between countries.	Communications and international ties
Main direction	Institutional structure. A phased process.	Differences between countries.	Culture.	Cultural and economic factors; communication; technology.
Problem of underdevelopment identified	Un-industrialized.	First World and Imperialism.	Social changes.	Communication systems need to adopt western-centric forms.
Key points in explaining inequality	Differing value systems and ideas. Immaturity of systems.	Regions and structural conditions.	Culture and the role of the state.	Cultural and economic factors

Scope-unit of analysis	Nation-State.	Nation-State.	International Connections.	Global Connection.
AIS in developing countries.	Adopted from developed countries.	Using developed countries' systems, which are inappropriate.	Accounting is a cultural issue.	Accounting is a global practice and a western model is adopted in developing countries.
Positive Aspects	Takes modern technology into consideration (Chase-Dunn 2000).	Takes into account the differences between developed and developing countries (Reyes 2001a).	Takes culture and social change into account. Unites socialist countries (Wallerstein 1979)	Takes into account the global environment, and does not ignore the culture aspects of the developing nations. It can be adapted more easily to the needs of a developing nation in a global economy(Reyes 2001a).
Negative aspects	Completely ignores the particular concerns of developing countries (Rostow 1962).	Western, capitalist systems are viewed negatively, as inappropriate to publicly owned enterprises(Reyes 2001a)..	It perceives that there is only one world system which is capitalism(Reyes 2001a).	It does not take into account the dramatic growth rate of developing countries (Intriligator 2004).

The Evolution of Development Discourse and Its Connection to Social Cohesion and Welfare States

The discourse on development has evolved over time, shaped by various theories, policies, and societal needs. Initially centered around economic growth, the concept of development has expanded to include social, political, and human dimensions. This shift has brought attention to the role of social cohesion and welfare states in fostering inclusive and sustainable development.

Development theories, such as modernization theory, dependency theory, and human development approaches, provide different perspectives on how societies progress. These theories highlight the importance of state policies, economic structures, and community participation in shaping development outcomes. Among these factors, social cohesion—the ability of a society to maintain unity, trust, and cooperation—emerges as a key determinant of sustainable growth. A lack of social cohesion often leads to inequality, political instability, and economic disparities, hindering long-term progress.

In response to these challenges, the welfare state model has played a crucial role in promoting equity, social security, and public welfare programs. Welfare policies, such as universal healthcare, education, and social protection, aim to reduce inequality and enhance social cohesion by ensuring that all citizens have access to essential resources.

By integrating discourse development with development theories, social cohesion, and welfare states, we can better understand how societies evolve and the policies that contribute to their stability and progress. This discussion is essential in shaping contemporary development strategies that prioritize economic growth alongside social well-being and inclusivity.

Social Cohesion

Social cohesion means how well the people in a society or ‘community get along with each other. It’s about unity, mutual trust, and working together, society with high social cohesion is one where people help each other, respect each other’s differences, and live in harmony despite their diverse backgrounds.

Social cohesion refers to the extent of connectedness and solidarity among groups in society. It identifies two main dimensions: the sense of belonging of a community and the relationships among members within the community itself.

Social cohesion is a social process which aims to consolidate plurality of citizenship by reducing inequality and socioeconomic disparities and fractures in the society. It reflects people’s needs for both personal development and a sense of belonging and links together individual freedom and social justice, economic efficiency and the fair sharing of resources, and pluralism and common rules for resolving all conflicts.

Discourse on Development and Social Cohesion

The relationship between development and social cohesion is a subject of extensive discourse in social and economic theories. Development, which has historically been assessed using economic indicators like GDP growth and industrial expansion, is now frequently viewed from a wider perspective that takes social factors into account. In contrast, social cohesion describes how strongly a society's members relate to one another, share values, and feel a sense of belonging. The confluence of these two ideas poses important queries regarding how governance, equity, and inclusivity contribute to long-term development.

According to one perspective, social cohesion naturally results from economic development because it raises living standards, reduces poverty, and creates opportunities. According to proponents of this theory, societies can invest in social infrastructure like healthcare and education as they grow wealthier, which promotes stability and unity. However, critics contend that development without inclusivity can undermine social cohesion by widening income disparities and marginalizing vulnerable populations. Unequal access to resources, employment, and political representation can fuel resentment and social unrest, as seen in various developing nations where economic growth has coincided with rising inequality.

An additional aspect of the discussion centers on how governance strikes a balance between social cohesion and economic advancement. Government policies that support social welfare, fair resource distribution, and the protection of marginalized communities are crucial, according to proponents of state-led development. On the other hand, neoliberal viewpoints support market-driven strategies, contending that privatization and economic liberalization promote productivity and creativity, which eventually benefit society as a whole. This method is frequently criticized, nevertheless, for ignoring the social safety nets that are required to preserve unity in heterogeneous and stratified societies.

In addition, the relationship between development and social cohesion is shaped by historical and cultural contexts. According to postcolonial scholars, social fragmentation rather than unity results from development models that are imposed by international organizations and frequently do not conform to local values and social structures. Similarly, globalization has introduced both integrative and divisive forces, where increased connectivity fosters cross-cultural exchange but also exacerbates social divides through uneven economic benefits.

In short, the discussion of social cohesion and development emphasizes the necessity of a well-rounded strategy that incorporates social and economic factors. Sustainable development should not only focus on economic indicators but also prioritize social equity, inclusion, and participatory governance. Development can only result in long-term social stability and cohesion if it guarantees that every member of society benefits from advancement.

Concept of the Welfare State

The welfare state refers to a concept of a state that focuses on ensuring that a broad range of social rights are provided for all citizens by acting on the social mechanisms and consequences of the market economy.

It refers to a government system that provides various social services to its citizens, aimed at ensuring a basic standard of living, social security, and protection against economic risks. This concept is rooted in the idea that the state has a responsibility to promote the well-being of its citizens, particularly the vulnerable and disadvantaged.

Functions:

States emphasize free primary health care to citizens. This is mainly done through government healthcare facilities.

Like schooling, free education for all, or at least up to a certain level.

Pension, particularly for government employees and people above sixty or disabled, is common in most countries.

And lastly, thorough social security coverage is a characteristic feature of developed countries.

Some countries also offer specialized support and incentives for their citizens depending on their economic situation, geography, etc.

Types:

There are three major types of welfare states.

I. The liberal welfare state

This type of state is market-oriented, i.e., the market and labor forces influence the state. Common benefits like health insurance and pensions depend on employment. Proponents of a liberal state argue that it supports individual rights and diversity and incentivizes based on eligibility. Here, minimum government interference is idealized. With the emergence of Neo liberalism the scope of liberal welfare state has shrunk and development became an illusion. Neo liberalism has completely failed the poorer citizens across the globe because the poorer have been pushed to the margins of society.

II. Social welfare state

Also known as a social democratic state, it pushes the idea of social welfare as a mandatory responsibility of a democratic government, i.e., the government is the absolute guarantor of social rights. Furthermore, a social welfare state is based on equal opportunity, regardless of employment status.

III. Conservative welfare state

A conservative welfare state refers to a social policy model that emphasizes traditional family structures, social insurance programs, and the importance of maintaining social order. This system often focuses on providing support primarily to those who are deemed deserving, such as the elderly or those with a long work history, rather than offering broad assistance to all citizens. It promotes individual responsibility while also recognizing the state's role in supporting individuals through specific social benefits.

The conservative welfare state is most commonly associated with countries like Germany and Austria, where social policies emphasize preserving traditional family roles and responsibilities.

Conclusion

The concept of development has shifted from a limited emphasis on economic growth to a broader, multi-dimensional framework encompassing social, political, and environmental aspects. While early theories like modernization promoted a Western-centered model of progress, later approaches such as dependency and world-systems theories underscored global inequalities. The influence of globalization and neoliberal policies further shaped development, often deepening economic and social disparities. In the present era, social cohesion and welfare states are seen as crucial for fostering sustainable and inclusive growth by ensuring fair access to resources, education, and healthcare. Achieving true development requires a balanced approach that integrates economic advancement with social well-being, stability, and structural reform to build an equitable and thriving society.

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